

Living With Flying-Foxes

Student evidence briefing and competing community messages

READING MISSION

ANSWER KEY

Mark **C** for community impact, **E** for ecological importance and **S** for a safe or lawful response. Box one sentence that corrects a misconception.

1 Night travellers and daytime camps

Flying-foxes are large fruit- and nectar-eating bats. They are **nocturnal**: they rest together in trees during the day, then fly out around dusk to feed. The trees used for resting and breeding are called a **camp** or **roost**. Food and camp use change with flowering, fruiting and seasons, so numbers at a camp can rise, fall or move.

As flying-foxes travel between feeding areas, they can carry pollen and seeds **E**. This helps native forests reproduce and connect across the landscape **E**. Their long-distance movement makes them important pollinators and seed dispersers **E**. Australia monitors flying-fox populations because grey-headed and spectacled flying-foxes are nationally listed as threatened **E**.

2 Why camps appear near people

Flying-foxes need flowering trees, feeding habitat and safe places to rest. Forest loss and fragmentation have reduced some natural habitat. Remaining patches of trees in towns, parks and along waterways can become useful camp sites. This can bring wildlife and people into closer contact.

A large or seasonal camp can create real challenges. Residents may experience noise, strong odour, droppings on cars or washing, damaged vegetation and interrupted sleep **C**. These impacts are not imaginary simply because flying-foxes are ecologically valuable. A fair community message should describe the exact impact instead of labelling the animals.

Quick evidence check

What could be checked?	What detail would make it precise?
The number of bats at a camp	Place, date, counting method and species
Residents reported noise	Who was asked, how many people and when
Flying-foxes move seeds	Which species, plants, distance and research source

Language alert

"A camp is present beside the park" is checkable. "A disgusting invasion has stolen our park" adds loaded judgement and metaphor.

Word help

nocturnal - active at night

camp or roost - trees where flying-foxes rest and breed

pollinator - an animal that moves pollen between flowers

fragmentation - when habitat is broken into smaller patches

Ecological value and community impact can both be true. Strong evidence describes each one precisely.

Health, safety and lawful coexistence

3

What the health advice actually says

CORRECTS MISCONCEPTION

Queensland Government advice says that catching disease directly from flying-foxes is extremely unlikely.

Australian Bat Lyssavirus can be transmitted through an untreated bite or scratch from an infected bat.

CORRECTS MISCONCEPTION

Living, walking or playing near a camp does not expose a person to the virus.

CORRECTS MISCONCEPTION

There is no evidence that Hendra virus passes directly from flying-foxes to people.

No touch means safe distance

Never touch, feed or try to rescue a flying-fox **S**. Keep people and pets away from an injured or grounded bat and contact a trained, vaccinated wildlife rescuer **S**. If a person is bitten or scratched, seek medical advice immediately **S**.

4 Practical responses

People living near a seasonal camp can reduce some impacts by planning ahead. Official suggestions include bringing washing in at night, parking vehicles under cover, covering outdoor items and maintaining buildings or water systems appropriately **S**. Avoiding disturbance can also reduce extra noise and stress **S**.

Flying-foxes and their roosts are protected under Queensland conservation law **S**. Some low-impact activities and council management actions are allowed only when current rules and codes are followed **S**. Management must not harm the animals **S**.

CORRECTS MISCONCEPTION

Moving a camp is not a simple “push them away” solution: flying-foxes are mobile, impacts can shift elsewhere, and disturbance can affect animals and nearby residents.

Practical, lawful action

Plan around nightly movement

Bring washing inside, cover outdoor items and park vehicles under cover where possible **S**.

Leave rescue to trained people

Keep people and pets back from an injured or grounded bat and contact a vaccinated wildlife rescuer **S**.

Check the current rules

Council action must follow Queensland conservation law, current codes and animal-welfare requirements **S**.

Management is not simple

Disturbance can create more noise, stress animals and move impacts to another place. A strong response checks evidence, safety, law and likely consequences **S**.

Evidence habit: When a health claim sounds alarming, check the pathway of exposure. “Near a camp” and “bitten or scratched by a bat” are not the same situation.

Audit the message before the council publishes it

5 A fair council message needs three things. These messages are fictional and deliberately positioned. Audit the language; neither is the official answer.

Accuracy

Include: Checkable facts and source limits

Avoid: Rumour or certainty without evidence

Respect

Include: Real community impacts and ecological value

Avoid: Mocking residents or demonising wildlife

Action

Include: Safe, lawful and practical steps

Avoid: Handling bats or unauthorised disturbance

Remember: Objective language is not automatically proven. A council should still check its source, date, place, measurement and limits.

Rivergum Council: two draft community messages

Compare purpose, evidence and positioning.

MESSAGE A | CLEAR THE CAMP NOW

RESIDENT ACTION GROUP DRAFT

A deafening invasion has taken over Rivergum Park.

Families are forced to endure unbearable noise, foul smells and dangerous animals beside their homes.

C

★ The camp is ruining our neighbourhood, and every responsible council would clear it immediately. Rivergum residents deserve their peaceful park back - no excuses and no delays.

MESSAGE B | WELCOME OUR NIGHT GARDENERS

WILDLIFE NETWORK DRAFT

Our wonderful night gardeners are bringing life to Rivergum Park. Flying-foxes move pollen and seeds through native forests **E**, so their camp is a precious gift.

Noise and droppings are only a tiny inconvenience

C, and there is nothing for residents to worry about.

★ Everyone should welcome the camp and leave nature completely alone.

Audit before you advise

1. Underline one checkable claim in each message. (Marked in red underline)

3. ★ Place a star beside one statement that mixes information and positioning.

2. Circle loaded phrase in each message. (Marked in red capsule)

4. Write one question the council should answer before publishing either message.

My question for Rivergum Council

Exemplar Answer: What exact scientific and legal evidence proves that attempting to clear or disperse the camp will not increase noise, stress animals, or push the camp directly into neighbouring residential backyards?

Source trail: Evidence briefing: original summary of Queensland Government *Living near flying-foxes*; Queensland Government *Bats and human health*; Queensland *Flying-fox roost management guideline*; and Australian Government DCCEEW flying-fox monitoring and conservation pages. Full links are in the Teacher Guide. Checked 29 July 2026.